STATE SCAN

PUNJAB: FULLBACK IS THE FALLBACK *PG 17*

GUJARAT: FROM ROSES TO RUINATION *PG 20*



HINDUSTAN TIMES

IN THE AFTERMATH
Closed gates of Chorebagan Sarbojanin Durga Puja pandal after the stampede and (opposite page) CM Adhikari

▶ WEST BENGAL

SHADOWS FALL ON A FESTIVAL

A stampede at a Durga puja pandal darkens festivities in Kolkata. As Opposition calls out a political coup at the committee, the Suvendu government finds itself trapped in a crowd of questions

By **Arkamoy Dutta Majumdar**

OCTOBER 17 WAS SAPTAMI, THE SECOND OF THE NINE DAYS of Durga Puja and the first of pandal festivities. Auspicious is the word reserved for it—no one's cue sheet marked it for a stampede that would leave 19 dead and 25 injured. But a sudden downpour, apparent fears that the pandal would fall, a narrow exit that doubled up as entrance, and a "chicken's neck alley" outside—all the sequential makers of a tragedy came together at Chorebagan in north Kolkata. Or so says one plausible reconstruction. Only one thing is certain: Kolkata had never seen anything like it before.

Consternation was inevitable for West Bengal's new government. It was the first Pujo ever under the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Opposition was raising cain even before it was over—calling out poor crowd control, police laxity and, most of all, a political change of guard at the puja committee. Chief minister Suvendu Adhikary, combative by mien, recalled past deaths, including 13 from electrocution